

Richland Cemetery Connected History Project

Technical & Partnership Brief – Version 1.1

Leatherwood Matters | [Historic Richland Cemetery](#) | Greenville, South Carolina

[AmeriCorps VISTA Project](#) – Grant/Contract #25VSHSC003

THE OPPORTUNITY

[Historic Richland Cemetery](#) already has an important geographic foundation through the City of Greenville's cemetery GIS and burial information. [Leatherwood Matters](#) is developing the complementary historical layer: who the people buried at Richland were, how they lived, and how they were connected to families and the larger Greenville community.

The challenge is not simply to build another database. It is to determine how these resources can work together responsibly.

CITY OF GREENVILLE – WHERE

Graves • Locations • [GIS](#) • Cemetery Records

LEATHERWOOD MATTERS – WHO

People • Families • History • Relationships • Evidence

Goal: ONE CONNECTED RESOURCE

WHAT ALREADY EXISTS

City Foundation: [Cemetery GIS](#), grave/location information, burial records, and existing aerial imagery.

Historical Foundation: Research, historical records, photographs, family relationships, military history, and community history.

Implementation Capacity: Two full-time [AmeriCorps VISTAs](#) — Data Systems & Research VISTA and Partnerships & Volunteer Systems VISTA.

Partner Capacity: City, libraries, historical organizations, community partners, volunteers, universities, and pro bono technical expertise.

THE CHALLENGE WE ARE WORKING THROUGH

Before significant system development begins, Leatherwood needs to determine the appropriate data architecture, standards, relationships, and workflows for developing the historical WHO while preserving and appropriately connecting with the City's existing WHERE.

Important decisions remain intentionally open: database architecture, relational data model, unique identifiers, GIS integration, data standards, grave-level navigation, public access, and QR/NFC or other connection methods.

Historical information should remain connected to its supporting evidence and source records.

WHAT WE WANT THE SYSTEM TO MAKE POSSIBLE

SEARCH → FIND → TOUR → CONNECT → DISCOVER



Residents, descendants, researchers, and visitors should eventually be able to search Richland's history, identify relevant people, locate graves, navigate the cemetery, explore thematic tours, and discover biographies, families, documents, photographs, and stories.

WHERE PROFESSIONAL EXPERTISE CAN HELP

1. How should the historical information be structured?

Expertise: Relational database architecture and data modeling.

2. How should WHERE + WHO connect?

Expertise: GIS/data integration and unique identifiers.

3. How should information be collected and verified?

Expertise: Data standards, evidence/provenance, and research workflows.

4. How can visitors reliably locate individual graves?

Expertise: GIS, aerial mapping, and navigation.

5. How should people access information at a grave?

Expertise: QR, NFC, and alternative access approaches.

6. How can the system survive changes in people and technology?

Expertise: Documentation, governance, portability, and handoff.

WHAT WE WOULD ASK A PRO BONO CONSULTANT TO ACCOMPLISH

One clearly defined challenge. One practical deliverable.

We are not asking one consultant to build the entire Richland system.

Depending on the consultant's expertise, a focused engagement might produce:

- A database architecture and data-model recommendation; OR
- A GIS integration and grave-navigation assessment.

The engagement should produce a documented recommendation/design and implementation roadmap that Leatherwood Matters and its VISTAs can carry forward.

This approach is consistent with [Taproot's](#) emphasis on a focused project with one concrete deliverable and [GISCorps'](#) short-term, defined-project model.

ROLES & LONG-TERM CAPACITY

City of Greenville: Geographic/cemetery foundation (WHERE).

Leatherwood Matters: Historical/person information (WHO).

Pro Bono Experts: Specialized assessment, design, and validation.

AmeriCorps VISTAs: Systems, workflows, implementation capacity, and knowledge transfer.

Community Partners & Volunteers: Research, stewardship, and continued growth.

Sustainable means documented, transferable, maintainable, and usable after the VISTAs and pro bono consultants complete their service.

PROJECT PRINCIPLES

Connect, don't duplicate.

Design before we build.

Evidence behind the history.

Keep technology flexible.

Build for long-term stewardship.